FREE CHECKLIST · November 2026

Pre-Publish Content SEO Checklist

41 on-page checks to run before you publish an article or page: search intent, headings, E-E-A-T, internal links, images and structured data.

7 sections · 41 checks

How to use this checklist

Add the list to your editorial workflow for every new piece and major update; the writer completes it and the editor signs off. Do not publish until all 'high' items are done; 'medium' items noticeably raise quality, and 'low' items are refinements for when time allows.

Priority: **High** **Medium** **Low**

01 Search intent and keywords

- [ ] **Review the top 10 results for the target keyword and write down the dominant search intent (informational, comparison, transactional, local).** — High
  How: Search the query in a private window and note the content types in the results (guide, list, product page) in a sheet.
- [ ] **Choose the content format to match the dominant intent; if the results are product listings, do not publish a long blog post.** — Medium
  How: Compare the draft's format with the most common format in the top 10; if different, justify it in the brief.
- [ ] **Confirm no other page on the site targets the same keyword; if one does, update it instead of creating a new page.** — High
  How: Filter the query in the Search Console Performance report to see which URLs get impressions; search site:domain.com "keyword".
- [ ] **List related sub-questions users ask alongside the main keyword and answer them in the content.** — Medium
  How: Collect questions from Google's 'People also ask' box and your keyword tool, and map them to the draft.
- [ ] **Use the keyword naturally; include synonyms and related terms instead of repeating the same phrase artificially.** — Medium
  How: Read the text aloud and rewrite forced repetition; use 'find' in your editor to see how often the main phrase appears.

02 Title tag, meta description and URL

- [ ] **Give every page a unique title tag that accurately summarises the content and leads with the main topic.** — High
  How: Check in a SERP preview tool whether the title is truncated; filter duplicate titles in your crawler.

- [ ] **Append the brand name at the end of the title with a consistent separator (e.g. ' | Brand') and avoid keyword stuffing.** Low
  How: Check the title template in your CMS and confirm no word appears twice in the title.
- [ ] **Write a page-specific meta description that explains the page's value and who it is for.** Medium
  How: Check how the description looks on mobile in a SERP preview tool and confirm no generic template text remains.
- [ ] **Set a short, lowercase URL with words separated by hyphens and no special or accented characters.** Low
  How: Check the CMS-generated slug before publishing and remove dates, IDs or unnecessary words.
- [ ] **Verify the page has a self-referencing canonical tag and no accidental noindex.** High
  How: Check rel=canonical and meta robots values in the page source on preview or after publishing.
- [ ] **If you change the URL of an existing page, add a 301 redirect from the old URL to the new one.** Medium
  How: Open the old URL and check the 301 status code and destination in the browser Network tab.

03 Heading structure, intro and readability

- [ ] **Use a single H1 that clearly states the main topic of the page.** High
  How: View the heading hierarchy with a browser extension and check there are no multiple or empty H1s.
- [ ] **Order H2 and H3 headings in a logical hierarchy; read on their own, the headings should summarise the content.** Medium
  How: Extract the heading tree and check for skipped levels (H2 to H4) and headings used only for styling.
- [ ] **Give a short, direct answer to the search question in the first 2-3 sentences of the intro.** High
  How: Read only the first paragraph and check whether the reader gets the core answer; cut any long preamble.
- [ ] **Keep paragraphs short and present steps, comparisons or list-like information as bullet points or tables.** Medium
  How: Find paragraphs that fill the whole screen in mobile preview and split them.
- [ ] **Explain terms when they first appear and use language suited to the target reader's level of knowledge.** Medium
  How: Have a colleague unfamiliar with the topic read the draft and mark terms they do not understand.
- [ ] **Fix spelling and grammar errors before publishing.** Medium
  How: Run the text through a spell checker and use a recognised style guide as reference.
- [ ] **End the content with a clear call to action showing the reader's next step (related guide, contact, product).** Low
  How: Check that the final section has a clickable link or button and that it goes to the right page.
- [ ] **Verify that on mobile the first screen of content is not covered by a large image, pop-up or ad.** Low
  How: Open the page on a real phone and check that the headline and intro are visible on the first screen.

04 E-E-A-T signals

- [ ] **Add a visible author name to the content and link it to an author page describing their expertise.** High
  How: Check the author name is clickable and the author page includes a bio, area of expertise and profile links.
- [ ] **Add a concrete example, photo, screenshot or data point from your own experience.** High
  How: Mark at least one element in the draft that only you can provide; use original images instead of stock.
- [ ] **Link statistics, quotes and technical claims to the primary source and state the date of the data.** High
  How: List every number and claim in the draft; source or remove those without a source.
- [ ] **For health, finance or legal topics, have the content reviewed by a qualified expert and check compliance with regulations and professional body rules.** High
  How: Show the reviewer's name and review date on the page and keep the sign-off in your editorial records.
- [ ] **Show the publication date, and the updated date after significant changes, on the page.** Medium
  How: Check that the dates on the page match datePublished and dateModified in the Article markup.
- [ ] **Verify the site has About, Contact and editorial policy pages and that they are reachable from the content.** Low
  How: Check the article template links to these pages from the footer or author box.

05 Internal links and anchor text

- [ ] **Link from the new content to at least 3 related existing pages using descriptive anchor text.** High
  How: Count internal links in the draft and replace generic anchors such as 'click here' with text describing the target page.
- [ ] **Add links to the new content from 2-3 strong, related existing pages.** High
  How: Find related pages with many links via a site:domain.com "topic" search or the Search Console Links report.
- [ ] **Verify that internal links point directly to final URLs returning 200, not to redirects or 404s.** Medium
  How: Crawl the page with your crawler after publishing and list outgoing links that return 3xx or 4xx.
- [ ] **Use anchor text for the same target page that is consistent across content but not identical everywhere.** Low
  How: Review the anchor texts pointing to the target URL in your crawler's internal anchor text report.
- [ ] **Check that external links go to trustworthy, current pages and that sponsored links use rel="sponsored".** Medium
  How: Open each external link in the draft and check the rel value on paid or affiliate links in the source.

06 Images and structured data

- [ ] **Write alt text for every informative image describing its content and role on the page; leave alt empty for decorative images.** Medium
  How: Review image fields in your CMS or use your crawler's 'images missing alt text' report.

- [ ] **Resize images to their display size, compress them as WebP or AVIF, and set width/height attributes.** — Medium
  How: Check image suggestions and the CLS value in PageSpeed Insights; CLS should be ≤ 0.1.
- [ ] **Do not lazy-load the page's largest image (the LCP element); confirm LCP stays under 2.5 seconds.** — Medium
  How: Identify the LCP element in PageSpeed Insights and check the image does not have loading="lazy" in the source.
- [ ] **Add structured data suited to the content type (Article, BreadcrumbList, Product for products) and keep it consistent with visible content.** — Medium
  How: Test the URL or code in the Rich Results Test and resolve errors and warnings before publishing.
- [ ] **If you use FAQPage markup for an FAQ section, do it to describe the content structure, not in expectation of a Google rich result.** — Low
  How: Remove any FAQ rich result goal from the brief or report; Google has not shown FAQ rich results since 7 May 2026.
- [ ] **Add og:title, og:description and og:image tags for social sharing.** — Low
  How: Check Open Graph tags in the source and test the share preview in the platforms' debugging tools.

07 After publishing

- [ ] **Right after publishing, test the live URL with Search Console URL Inspection and request indexing.** — High
  How: In URL Inspection, confirm 'Test live URL' shows the page is indexable, then choose 'Request indexing'.
- [ ] **Verify the new URL is included in your XML sitemap.** — Medium
  How: Open the sitemap in a browser and search for the URL; check the last read date under Sitemaps in Search Console.
- [ ] **7-14 days after publishing, check the page is indexed and that Google's selected canonical matches yours.** — High
  How: Compare 'User-declared canonical' and 'Google-selected canonical' in URL Inspection.
- [ ] **4-8 weeks after publishing, review the queries the page earns impressions for and expand the content to cover gaps.** — Medium
  How: Filter the page URL in the Search Console Performance report and compare the Queries tab with the content.
- [ ] **Set a next review date for each piece of content and add it to your content calendar.** — Medium
  How: Add 'published', 'last updated' and 'next review' columns to your content inventory.

Detailed guides

- Content strategy guide
- Keyword research guide
- Content for E-E-A-T
- Internal linking
- Search Console guide
- SERP preview tool

Need a second pair of eyes on your site? Book a free intro call:
fatihemincakiroglu.com/en/book-a-call

This checklist reflects publicly documented Google guidance as of November 2026. Search features change; check the official documentation before major decisions.